



Red river gum (*Eucalyptus camaldulensis*) has aromatic, astringent leaves. When it is taken internally, generally to treat diarrhea, it turns the saliva red.

medicinal use elsewhere, for example gotu kola (*Centella asiatica*, p. 76) and visnaga (*Ammi visnaga*, p. 62), which have a long history of medicinal use in India and the Middle East. Early British settlers imported European medicinal plants, such as vervain (*Verbena officinalis*, p. 149), hawthorn (*Crataegus oxycantha*, p. 87), mullein (*Verbascum thapsus*, p. 281), and dandelion (*Taraxacum officinale*, p. 141), which have now all become naturalized. Native American plants have also found their way to Australia, including prickly pear (*Opuntia ficus-indica*, p. 242) and Canadian fleabane (*Conyza canadensis*, p. 194). As Australian herbalists generally follow the Anglo-American herbal tradition, these plants are often employed in local practice.

Chinese Influence

Traditional Chinese medicine has substantially influenced herbalism in Australia. Following the arrival of Chinese immigrants in the 19th century, herbal formulas gained a reputation for effectiveness, and Chinese medicine maintained a small but loyal following in all the major cities. During the 1980s, a renaissance in all branches of herbal medicine began, and today Australia has three colleges of traditional Chinese medicine. In 2012, traditional Chinese medicine became a nationally regulated form of medicine, with practitioners required to register with the Chinese Medicine Board of Australia. Naturopathy and Western herbal medicine are yet to achieve this status.

The Future

With the passing of enlightened legislation—the Therapeutic Goods Act—in 1989, herbal medicine became a dynamic growth industry in Australia. This process is likely to continue as Australia and New Zealand are due to harmonize their medicines legislation. Quality standards for over-the-counter herbal medicines have been raised and many new herbal products developed. There is increased commercial cultivation of medicinal plants, notably tea tree (*Melaleuca alternifolia*, p. 112), and university training and herbal research has been expanded. In this environment, Australians are becoming increasingly sophisticated in their use of natural medicines.

With its ancient culture, ties to Western herbalism, and location on the Pacific Rim, Australia is host to many herbal traditions. The next 20 years will doubtless see further exciting developments.

Gotu kola (*Centella asiatica*, p. 76) is a cleansing tonic for the skin and digestion. It also strengthens the nervous system and improves the memory.

Dried gotu kola

Fresh gotu kola leaves

Gotu kola powder

Eucalyptus (*Eucalyptus globulus*, p. 96) leaves were traditionally used by Aborigines to treat fevers and infections. Eucalyptus is a warming and stimulant herb. As well as being strongly antiseptic, it is effective in relieving colds, coughs, and sore throats.

Dried eucalyptus leaves

Dried, crushed eucalyptus leaves